BUILT ENVIRONMENT IMPACT BRIEF

WHAT PA'S 2026 ELECTIONS MEAN FOR THE BUILT ENVIRONMENT

November 4, 2026 · Build Philly Now · PA housing + transit coalition analysis

PRELIMINARY — UNOFFICIAL RETURNS, SEVERAL RACES UNCALLED

STATEWIDE: A DEMOCRATIC TRIFECTA

Democrats expanded their state House majority and **flipped the state Senate for the first time since 1994**, while Gov. Shapiro won re-election. For both housing and transit, control of the Senate is the whole story: it is the chamber where House-passed zoning and transit-funding bills went to die (transit, p. 4).

~108 / 203

STATE HOUSE — DEMOCRATIC

Up from 103. Net ≈ **+5**. Six R→D flips called; 7 races still uncalled.

26 / 50

STATE SENATE — DEMOCRATIC

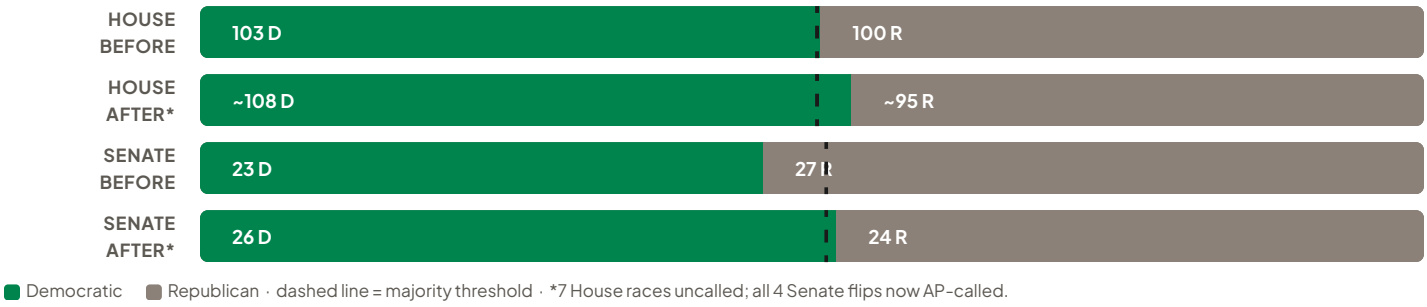
Up from 23 (was R 27–23). Net **+3**. All 4 flips AP-called. First D majority in 30+ years.

3

BRANCHES ALIGNED

House + Senate + Governor. Bills can now move through **both** chambers.

CHAMBER CONTROL, BEFORE AND AFTER

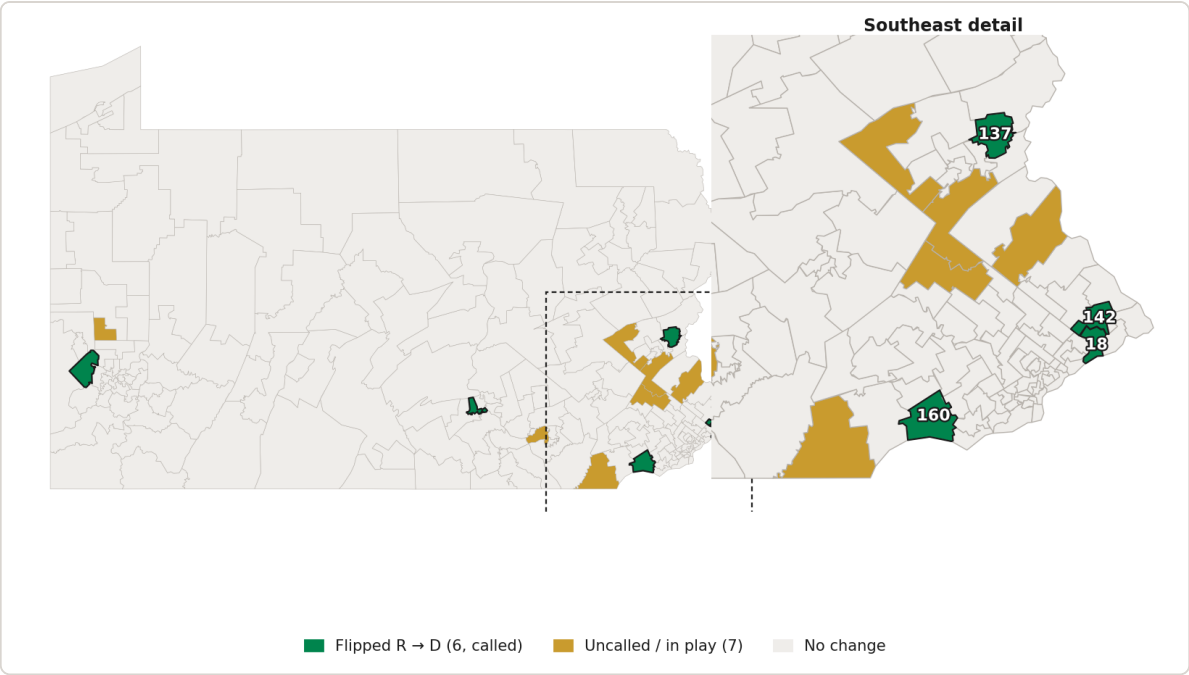


BOTTOM LINE

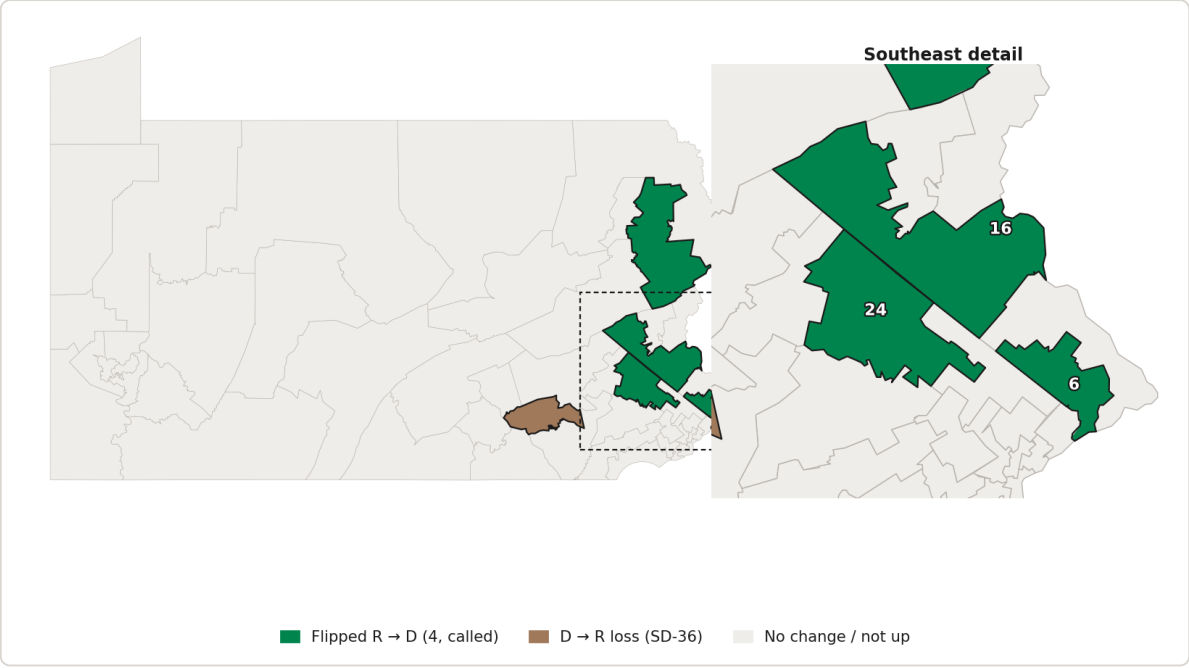
The House never killed these bills — HB 2186 passed 139–62 and HB 2109 passed 123–78. They died in a Republican Senate. A Democratic Senate, House, and Governor turns "passes the House, dies in the Senate" into a bill that can actually reach Shapiro's desk. The cost: the bipartisan Republican bench thinned — two of the reform coalition's most reliable Republicans lost (see p. 3).

WHERE THE SEATS CHANGED HANDS

Nearly every flip is in the **southeast suburban collar** — our softest, most-gettable Republican tier — plus the **Lehigh Valley**. The deep-red rural regions did not move. No opponents were converted; the gains came from suburban seats changing party outright.



STATE HOUSE — 6 FLIPS, ALL R→D. Bucks (HD-18, HD-142), Delaware/Chester (HD-160), Lehigh Valley/Northampton (HD-137), Harrisburg metro/Cumberland (HD-88, open seat), and Allegheny (HD-44). Amber = 7 uncalled races (including one Democratic seat, HD-12, that could still flip R).



STATE SENATE — THE CHAMBER FLIPS. All four flips now AP-called R→D: SD-6 (Bucks), SD-24 (Montgomery/Berks), SD-16 (Lehigh/Bucks), SD-40 (NEPA). SD-36 (Lancaster) flipped D→R — but the incoming Republican, Tom Jones, voted Yea on HB 2186 (ADU) as a House member, so it may not be a housing loss.

All figures unofficial as of the morning of Nov. 4, 2026. Seat counts are projections; 7 House and the four Senate flips are now AP-called. Verify against certified PA Department of State returns before publishing.

HOW THE MEMBERS WHO LOST VOTED ON LAST YEAR'S HOUSING BILLS

Every House member who lost (or whose open seat flipped) was a Republican. Their records on the two 2026 House zoning bills — **HB 2186** (accessory dwelling units) and **HB 2109** (occupancy reform) — on final passage:

DISTRICT / REGION	MEMBER (LOST)	HB 2186 ADU	HB 2109 OCCUPANCY	STATUS
HD-142 Bucks	Joe Hogan	Yea	Yea	ANCHOR — YEA ON BOTH
HD-137 Lehigh Valley	Joe Emrick	Yea	Yea	ANCHOR — YEA ON BOTH
HD-44 Allegheny	Valerie Gaydos	Yea	Yea	YEA ON BOTH
HD-18 Bucks	K.C. Tomlinson	Nay	Yea	SPLIT
HD-88 Cumberland	Sheryl Delozier	Nay	Yea	RETIRED — OPEN SEAT
HD-160 Delaware/Chester	Craig Williams	Nay	Nay	NAY ON BOTH

Final-passage roll calls (HB 2186 rc 1075; HB 2109 rc 1119). Note: this differs from the June crosstab, which used HB 2109 2nd Consideration — Gaydos and Williams both moved between the two readings. Senators who lost do not appear here; they don't vote on House bills.

Read (no assuming the newcomers): three reliable reform Republicans were removed by voters — Hogan, Emrick, Gaydos (Yea on both). Their Democratic successors are unproven — none has voted on these bills — so the honest accounting is a loss of two rock-solid Republican champions (Hogan, Emrick), not a swap for new Yeas. Williams was a No on both, so his seat is open ground rather than a lock against us. Whether the newcomers vote Yea is a conversation we haven't had yet.

IMPACT ON THE HOUSING & TRANSPORTATION COMMITTEES

COMMITTEE	OFF THE COMMITTEE — LOST (UNELECTED)	PENDING (HOUSE RACES UNCALLED)
Senate Urban Affairs & Housing	**Frank Farry** (SD-6) & **Jarrett Coleman** (SD-16, a rare R cosponsor) — both defeated	—
House Housing & Community Dev.	**K.C. Tomlinson** (HD-18, R) — defeated	Milou Mackenzie (HD-131, R)
House Transportation	**K.C. Tomlinson** (HD-18, R) — defeated	Shelby Labs (HD-143), Donna Scheuren (HD-147)
Senate Local Government	**Rosemary Brown** (SD-40, R) — defeated	—
Senate Transportation	**Rosemary Brown** (SD-40, R) — defeated	—
House Local Government	none called	Brett Miller (HD-41, R)

Delozier (HD-88) also left, but by **retiring**, not losing — and she sat on none of these committees. Rosters are rebuilt next session; under Democratic control both chambers' committees get new Democratic chairs (next page).

TRANSIT FUNDING: THE SAME SENATE WALL

Housing wasn't the only built-environment fight killed in the Senate. **HB 1788** — a ~$292M/year increase to the Public Transportation Trust Fund plus $325M in road/bridge bonding — passed the House **108–95**, then stalled: the Republican Senate **tabled Sen. Nikil Saval's amendment (A–1617)** that would have funded transit, **27–22** on a party line. Same chamber, same wall as zoning.

108–95

HB 1788 — PASSED HOUSE

The transit + roads funding package cleared the House, then went to Senate Transportation.

27–22

SENATE TABLED IT

The R majority tabled Saval's amendment to fund transit — a party-line vote.

4

ANTI-TRANSIT SENATORS DEFEATED

All four voted to table transit funding. All four lost — and the Senate is now 26–24 D.

THE ANTI-TRANSIT VOTES THAT ARE GOING AWAY

Every defeated Republican senator voted **to table** the Saval transit amendment:

DISTRICT	SENATOR (DEFEATED)	VOTE ON SAVAL TRANSIT AMENDMENT
SD-6	Frank Farry	Tabled it — anti-transit
SD-24	Tracy Pennycuick	Tabled it — anti-transit
SD-16	Jarrett Coleman	Tabled it — anti-transit
SD-40	Rosemary Brown	Tabled it — anti-transit

Plus three House Republicans who voted **No on HB 1788** are gone: Gaydos (HD-44), Emrick (HD-137), and Delozier (HD-88, retired).

BUT HOUSING ≠ TRANSIT — THE COALITIONS AREN'T THE SAME PEOPLE

The built-environment lens shows these are different coalitions. Each departing (or incoming) member's stance on the two fights:

MEMBER	HOUSING (HB 2186/2109)	TRANSIT (HB 1788)	NOTE
HD-142 Joe Hogan	Pro	Pro	Pro-both — the biggest combined loss
HD-137 Joe Emrick	Pro	Anti	Housing anchor, but No on transit
HD-44 Valerie Gaydos	Pro	Anti	Yea on both bills, No on transit
HD-160 Craig Williams	Anti	Pro	Mirror image — No on housing, Yea on transit
HD-18 K.C. Tomlinson	Split	Pro	Split on housing, Yea on transit
SD-36 Tom Jones INCOMING	Pro	Anti	Up from HD-98 — pro-ADU, but beat pro-transit Malone

BOTTOM LINE FOR TRANSIT

The Senate that tabled transit funding no longer has the votes: 4 of the 27 who tabled it are gone and the chamber is 26–24 D. The amendment's own author, Saval, is in the new majority, and Judy Ward (SD-30), who chairs Senate Transportation where HB 1788 sat, is likely to hand that gavel to a Democrat. The soft spot: SD-36, where pro-transit Malone lost to Jones, who voted against HB 1788.

NEW GAVELS: WHO IS LIKELY TO CHAIR THE HOUSING & TRANSPORTATION COMMITTEES

Because the **Senate** flipped, its current Democratic "minority chairs" are the people in line to take the gavel. The House was already Democratic, so those chairs are unchanged. The highest-leverage change for the built environment: **Nikil Saval** — a leading pro-housing voice and the author of the tabled transit-funding amendment — is in line to chair Senate Urban Affairs & Housing, the committee that gated the zoning bills.

Not final. The Senate Democratic caucus doesn't organize or assign committee chairs until the new year. The names below are the likely incoming chairs based on who holds the Democratic committee-leader posts now — not a done deal.

SENATE URBAN AFFAIRS & HOUSING
from Joe Picozzi (R, SD-5)
▼ likely to
Nikil Saval (D, SD-1)

SENATE LOCAL GOVERNMENT
from Dawn Keefer (R, SD-31)
▼ likely to
Patty Kim (D, SD-15)

SENATE TRANSPORTATION
from Judy Ward (R, SD-30)
▼ likely to
Marty Flynn (D, SD-22)

House chairs (unchanged, already Democratic): **Housing & Community Development** — Brandon Markosek (HD-25); **Local Government** — Bob Freeman (HD-136); **Transportation** — Ed Neilson (HD-174).

LIKELY SENATE DEMOCRATIC LEADERSHIP

ROLE (CURRENT MINORITY → MAJORITY)	SENATOR
Democratic Leader	**Jay Costa** (SD-43)
Whip	Tina Tartaglione (SD-2)
Caucus Chair	Maria Collett (SD-12)
Appropriations Chair	Vincent Hughes (SD-7)
Policy Chair	Nick Miller (SD-14)

Unresolved: the caucus has not held its organizational vote. Jay Costa, Democratic Leader since 2010, is the presumptive pick for **President Pro Tempore** or **Majority Leader**, but no reporting yet confirms who takes which post. Treat specific leadership claims as speculative until the caucus votes.

Current Republican holders being displaced: Kim Ward (President Pro Tempore) and Joe Pittman (Majority Leader).

WHAT TO WATCH

- **Senate now settled:** all four flips AP-called → a 26–24 Democratic majority, and the Senate committee losses are confirmed at three Republicans (Farry, Coleman, Brown).
- **HD-12** (the one Democratic House seat that could still flip R) sets whether the House net is +5 or +4.
- **Re-target the Senate nesting map.** Our prior targets — Ward (SD-30), Langerholc (SD-35), Picozzi (SD-5) — all survived; the chamber turned on other seats, so targeting logic changes under Democratic control.

Sources (all unofficial): MultiState PA-2026 results; Spotlight PA; Philadelphia Inquirer live results; WHYY; Daily Voice; PublicSource; Ballotpedia/PoliticsPA. Committee rosters and leadership from pasenate.com / pahouse.com (2025–26 session). Vote records from PA House roll calls rc 1075 & rc 1119. Figures subject to change until counties certify.

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RETARGETING: WHO TO WORK NOW

With a Democratic majority, the housing nesting map isn't about prying bills out of a hostile committee anymore — it's about a **durable bipartisan margin** and **protecting a thin majority**. "Support" below is the recorded share of a senator's nested House districts that voted Yea on HB 2186 (ADU) — this term's real votes. We don't assume the newcomers; the nesting tells us the district's terrain, not how a new member will vote.

SURVIVING REPUBLICANS ON PRO-REFORM DELEGATIONS

Demonstrated support — the bipartisan-margin targets, unchanged by the election:

SD	SENATOR (R)	HB 2186 NEST
35	Langerholc	100%
37	Robinson	100%
5	Picozzi	75%
49	Laughlin	75%
25	Dush	75%
34	Rothman	67%

NEW PEOPLE TO TALK TO NOW

Incoming senators — all unproven — ranked by what their district's recorded nesting gives us to open with:

SD	NEW SENATOR	DISTRICT NEST
40	Wrightson (D)	75%
24	Thomas (D)	67%
6	Albillar (D)	50%
16	Pinsley (D)	20%
36	Jones (R)	PROVEN ADU

Tom Jones (SD-36) is the exception — up from HD-98, he's a proven ADU Yea, so lead with his own record, not his district.

INCOMING HOUSE MEMBERS — ALL SIX FLIPPED SEATS, NONE HAS VOTED

- **Truly unknown, engage first** (districts leaned Nay on ADUs): Allen (HD-18), Agerton (HD-88), Moro (HD-160).
- **Ask them to hold the Yea their district showed** (replaced Yea Republicans): Egan (HD-142), Warren (HD-137), Haas (HD-44).

THE ASK HAS CHANGED

Before: pry bills past a hostile Republican committee. Now: hold a bipartisan margin (Langerholc, Robinson, Picozzi, Rothman), protect the thin new majority, and — above all — have the conversations the newcomers haven't had yet. The nesting says which districts are friendly terrain; it never says how a new member will vote.

Nesting method: primary-nested House districts (land overlap ≥ 0.5) per the project's Senate↔House overlay, scored against HB 2186 Final Passage (rc 1075). Recorded votes only; flipped seats scored as no-record, not Yea.